26TH KNESSET · ELECTION DAY 27 OCT 2026 · FORECAST FROZEN 26 OCT 2026

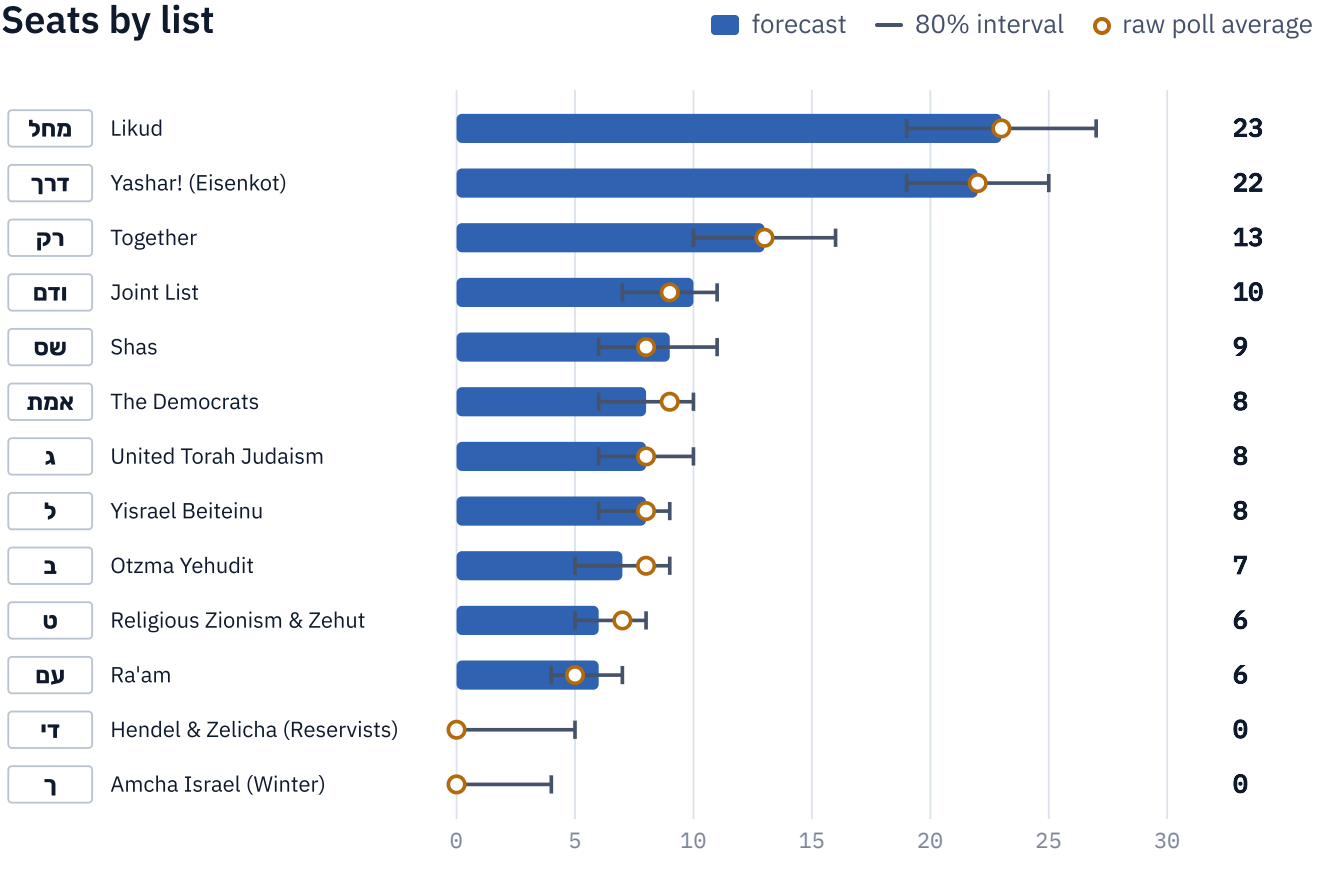
Knesset 26 Seat Forecast

A single seat forecast for every list and a single national turnout figure. Built from 82 published polls, eight past elections' polling errors, and ballot-box results back to 2003. Each correction is chosen by out-of-sample tests, not by taste.

The forecast

Seats minimise the expected competition score (sum of absolute seat errors), subject to 120 seats and feasible values (a list gets 0 or at least 4).

Seats by list



National turnout

71.2%

80% range 69.0–73.3% · 2022: 70.6%

Netanyahu bloc (Likud, Otzma, Shas, UTJ, RZP–Zehut)

53 seats

Simulated median 52; P(≥ 61) = 2.2%

Threshold lists

0 and 0 seats

Hendel–Zelicha passes in 38% of simulations, Amcha Israel in 22%. Below 50%, zero is the error-minimising call.

Expected score of this forecast (model-based)

18.9

sum of absolute seat errors; in the backtest the raw poll average scored 20.0 per election

List	Letters	Raw poll avg %	Corrected %	Sim. median	80% i
Likud	מחל	17.23	17.88	23	
Yashar! (Eisenkot)	דרך	16.91	17.17	22	
Together (Bennett-Lapid)	רק	9.91	10.07	13	
The Democrats	אמת	7.04	6.65	8	
Yisrael Beiteinu	ל	5.98	5.91	7	
Otzma Yehudit	ב	6.44	5.66	7	
Shas	שס	6.31	6.74	8	
United Torah Judaism	ג	6.04	6.11	8	
Religious Zionism & Zehut	ט	5.58	4.90	6	
Joint List (Hadash-Ta'al-Balad)	ודם	6.91	7.31	9	
Ra'am	עם	4.44	4.70	6	
Hendel & Zelicha (Reservists)	די	2.88	2.93	0	

List	Letters	Raw poll avg %	Corrected %	Sim. median	80% i
Amcha Israel (Winter)	ר	2.82	2.48	0	
Blue & White (withdrew)	כן	–	–	–	
Total					

Method in brief

1. Truth and segments. Official ballot-box results for 2003–2022 are pooled in a common party-family space and clustered (k-means, Gaussian mixture, Ward, NMF; K = 4–14; ballot-box and settlement level) into voter segments with the same meaning in every election.

2. How polls fail. For eight elections (2009–2022), every firm's final-fortnight polls are compared with the official result. Two families of error models are estimated. One is *industry bias* by party family, with empirical-Bayes shrinkage. The other is a *composition model*: each pollster's sample is treated as a re-weighting of the true segments, $\pi_k \propto w_k \cdot e^{\rho_k}$, fitted by gradient descent on the Hellinger distance between modelled and published family shares. The fitted model says polls over-sample national-religious areas and under-sample Arab, Haredi and traditional-periphery areas.

3. Model choice by backtest. Every candidate is scored by leave-one-election-out on the competition metric. Pollster-specific house effects carry over across elections only weakly (r = 0.16, permutation p = 0.011), and pollster-specific corrections do not beat the shared correction out of sample. Picking the single best clustering is a trap: nested selection scores worse than the raw average. The pre-specified candidate with the lowest backtest score is used (ties go to the primary model, the ensemble): the ensemble of the shrunk industry bias and the segment-composition model averaged over all NMF segmentations. In 2026 terms: Arab lists +6%, Shas +7%, UTJ +2%, Centre lists 2%, Left -5%, far-right lists -12%.

4. 2026. Polls fielded in the final ten days (time-weighted, half-life 4 days) are averaged with one vote per firm, after removing Blue & White. The corrections are applied, and 20,000+ elections are simulated. The simulation uses error sizes measured out of sample by list size, a shared family shock, and a "which firms are right" shock along the main axis of 2026 disagreement. Each draw goes through the legal allocation (3.25% of all valid votes, quota floor, Bader-Ofer with the five surplus agreements).

5. The single guess. The score is a sum of absolute errors, so the optimal guess for each list is its simulated median. Medians are adjusted to a feasible, 120-seat composition by the smallest increase in expected error. Turnout comes from a structural decomposition (domestic electorate × sector turnout), calibrated on 2022, with the median reported.

Data and verification

100,740 ballot-box results, 10 elections (2003–2022)	516 historical seat polls, 8 elections	82 2026 polls collected (6 Sep – 23 Oct)
28 polls in the final window, from 9 firms		

- **True results:** official Central Elections Committee ballot-box files for Knesset 16–25 (2003–2022): votes25…votes21.bechirot.gov.il and the CEC files on data.gov.il. Double-envelope rows (soldiers, diplomats, prisoners) are kept for national totals and excluded from geography. Party letters are mapped to lists and to nine party families. Computed seat allocation reproduces the official 2022 result exactly.
- **Historical polls:** every seat projection in the final list-configuration table of the Wikipedia polling pages for 2009–2022 (the aggregator the competition recommends), parsed with a rowspan/colspan-aware grid. Firms are linked into lineages (Midgam, Kantar/Teleseker, Lazar/Panels, Direct Polls, Maagar Mochot …).
- **Second historical poll source:** every seat poll of the final 30 days before each election 2009–2022 was collected again, independently, from Hebrew Wikipedia. Hebrew Wikipedia has no poll table for 2009, 2013 or 2015, so for those years the polls came from archived originals (the outlets' own articles, bhirot2009/2013 poll pages, IMRA digests, Project 61, Knesset Jeremy). A separate agent then re-checked every row of each file against the sources and fixed 22 rows; 3 missing polls were added (step 04b). Of the 299 polls in this source, 272 match an English-Wikipedia poll (same election, same firm, dates within 2 days, or 4 days for near-identical tables). 262 of those have identical seat tables, and the mean difference is 0.06 seats. The 27 polls missing from English Wikipedia were

added to the history, 12 of them in the final fortnight that the back-test uses (2013: 8, 2015: 10, 2019: 1). All results below use this merged history.

- **2026 polls:** the Wikipedia 2026 page was checked with the two AI agents' collections. All 48 polls found in both sources agree seat for seat (0 discrepancies). Seven agent-only polls were checked against their sources (e.g. the i24 23.10 article and the DRI report on the CEC site). CEC poll reports supply the percentages of lists polled below the threshold. Every poll's seats are converted to votes exactly as in the historical calibration: a list with s seats gets the midpoint of the vote range that Bader-Ofer maps to s seats, (s + ½)·T/(S + J/2). This reproduces the CEC raw percentages closely; for example Israel Hayom 22 Oct gives Hendel 3.42% vs 3.7% raw and Likud 16.35% vs 16.5%. The measured corrections and error sizes therefore apply unchanged. Using the reports' raw percentages instead is shown as a sensitivity variant.
- **Race facts:** Blue & White withdrew on 19 Oct (CEC-confirmed 21 Oct) and is set to 0. Surplus-vote agreements (Yalkut HaPirsumim 15045): Together–Yisrael Beiteinu, Joint List–Ra'am, RZP–Zehut–Likud, UTJ–Shas, Democrats–Yashar. Electorate: 7,331,981 eligible voters.

Voter segments from the true results

About 100,000 ballot-box results (and, separately, ~12,000 settlement results) from 10 elections are pooled in one 9-family vote-share space, so a segment means the same thing in every election.

Four clustering algorithms were run, each at K = 4–14 (NMF up to 8, the number of families) and at two units (ballot box and settlement): k-means and a Gaussian mixture on Hellinger-transformed shares, Ward hierarchical clustering, and non-negative matrix factorisation (soft archetypes). Internal validity favours few segments: silhouette, Calinski–Harabasz and stability peak at K = 4. Internal indices cannot say which segmentation explains *pollster error*, though, so the deciding test is downstream (next sections).

Algorithm	Unit	Best K	Silhouette	Calinski-H.	Davies-B.	Stability
k-means	ballot	4	0.333	4129	1.02	0
k-means	settlement	4	0.375	3898	1.00	0
Gaussian mixture	ballot	4	0.283	3347	1.19	0
Gaussian mixture	settlement	4	0.334	3521	1.13	0
Ward hierarchical	ballot	4	0.331	4085	1.00	0

Algorithm	Unit	Best K	Silhouette	Calinski-H.	Davies-B.	Stability
Ward hierarchical	settlement	4	0.383	3870	0.99	
NMF archetypes	ballot	4	0.324	3996	1.03	0
NMF archetypes	settlement	6	0.320	3194	1.16	0

* Downstream: mean leave-one-election-out score of the composition model built on that algorithm (averaged over K, test across algorithms: $\chi^2 = 3.19$, $p = 0.363$. No algorithm is significantly better; NMF ranks first.

Illustration: NMF archetypes, K = 8, ballot level

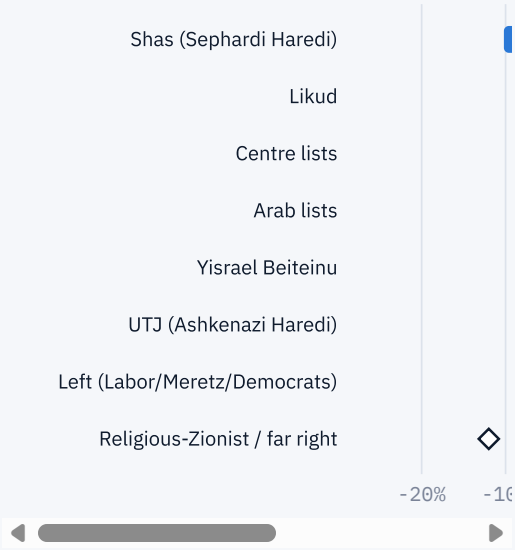
Segment (dominant families)	Share of 2022 v
Secular centre (Centre lists 48%, Likud 21%)	3
Likud heartland (Likud 41%, Centre lists 19%)	2
Arab localities (Arab lists 88%, Centre lists 3%)	1
Double envelopes: soldiers, diplomats, etc. (Centre lists 28%, Likud 24%)	
Haredi areas (UTJ 61%, Shas 24%)	
National-religious areas (Far right 53%, Likud 20%)	
Shas-strong periphery (Shas 44%, UTJ 20%)	
Russian-speaking areas (Yisrael Beiteinu 30%, Centre lists 24%)	
Centre-left urban (Left 46%, Centre lists 32%)	

Segment profile in 2022 (share of each party family within the segment) and the industry-wide representation ratio estimated by the composition model: how strongly the average poll weights the segment relative to its true share of voters. Above 1 = over-represented in polls.

How the polls erred, 2009–2022

Average poll error by party family

Two systematic errors stand out across elections (size-weighted family errors, lists the polls actually measured). **Religious-Zionist and far-right lists are over-estimated** (about +20% of their true share; t-test p = 0.023). **Shas is under-estimated** (about -10%; p =



Pollster-balanced final-fortnight average versus the official result, as a % of the list's true vote share; one observation per election (n = 8). Right = polls over-estimate. p-values: one-sample t-test / Wilcoxon signed-rank across elections. The diamond is the correction finally applied to 2026 (opposite sign, shrunk).

0.057); in 2022 it was polled at 8.5 seats and won 11. Arab lists lean under-estimated, and Likud has twice been badly under-polled (2015, April 2019), but neither family's error is significant.

The composition model explains the pattern structurally. It estimates that polls over-weight national-religious settlements and under-weight Arab, Haredi and traditional-periphery ballot boxes.

Pollster house effects measured relative to the other firms in the same election carry over to the next election only weakly. Across 460 firm-family-election pairs, r = 0.16 (permutation p = 0.011), and the carry-over slope is 0.29 ± 0.08. They persist for Shas and Centre lists and are noise elsewhere.

Pollster profiles and "weight matrices"

One profile per polling firm with final-fortnight polls in at least two of the eight back-test elections. Standard errors are leave-one-election-out jackknife.

Each firm was profiled three ways. First, as a **pollster × party-family bias matrix**: its average error by family. Second, as a **bias + slope matrix**: per firm and family, a line relating its poll shares to the true shares. Third, as a **pollster × voter-segment representation matrix**: how heavily its sample weights each segment found in the ballot-box results.

The profiles are remarkably alike. Every firm over-estimates the far right, under-estimates Shas and Likud and over-estimates the left. The industry slope is 0.84, so polls compress the real differences between lists. Direct Polls was the least biased on Likud and the far right; Midgam and Dialog/Fuchs were the most biased on Shas (about −13%).

Firm-specific deviations from the shared pattern are small and only weakly persistent from one election to the next (r = 0.16, carry-over slope 0.29). So in the backtest none of the pollster-specific matrices beats the industry-level correction: the extra parameters fit noise.

In the forecast, every firm therefore gets the same correction, and the 2026 firms' unprecedented disagreement is handled as uncertainty (see "The 2026 polls").

Lineages of the 2026 firms: Channel 12 is Midgam; Kan 11 and Israel Hayom are Kantar; Maariv and Walla are Lazar; Channel 16 is Maagar Mochot; i24 is Direct Polls. Channel 14 (Filber/NEXT DATA), Channel 13 (Madad consortium), Zman Yisrael (Tatika) and DRI have no back-test history.

Pollster × party-family bias (% of the family's true vote share; ± jackknife SE)

Firm (elections)	Likud	Shas	UTJ	Far right	YB	Centre	Left	Ara
Dialog / Camil Fuchs (6)	-7 ±6	-13 ±8	-2 ±4	+17 ±7	-6 ±7	-3 ±5	+12 ±9	+1
Direct Polls (4)	-2 ±6	-9 ±5	-2 ±6	+11 ±13	+11 ±9	-4 ±4	+8 ±19	+0
Kantar / Teleseker (8)	-5 ±4	-11 ±6	+0 ±3	+18 ±6	+4 ±3	-3 ±3	+12 ±8	-3
Lazar / Panels Politics (8)	-5 ±5	-12 ±6	-2 ±3	+22 ±6	+3 ±6	-4 ±4	+9 ±8	-4
Maagar Mochot (8)	-5 ±6	-6 ±5	+2 ±3	+21 ±8	+0 ±6	-6 ±5	+10 ±7	+1
Midgam (Mano Geva) (8)	-7 ±5	-12 ±5	-0 ±2	+17 ±6	+2 ±4	-4 ±4	+16 ±7	-5
Smith (8)	-5 ±5	-4 ±5	-3 ±2	+16 ±5	-0 ±4	-5 ±4	+9 ±7	-1

Pollster × voter-segment representation (composition model; 1 = represented in proportion)

Firm	Secular centre	Likud heartland	Arab localities	Double envel
Industry (all firms)	**×0.87**	**×0.54**	**×0.84**	
Dialog / Camil Fuchs	×0.90	×0.52	×0.88	
Direct Polls	×0.87	×0.56	×0.82	
Kantar / Teleseker	×0.89	×0.53	×0.83	
Lazar / Panels Politics	×0.88	×0.52	×0.84	
Maagar Mochot	×0.87	×0.54	×0.70	
Midgam (Mano Geva)	×0.92	×0.49	×0.81	
Smith	×0.85	×0.56	×0.86	

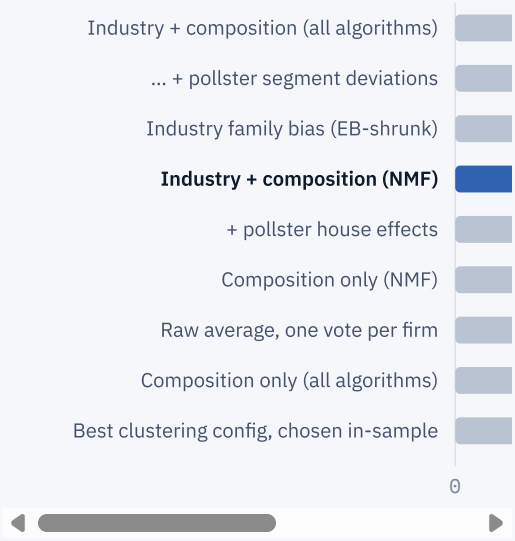
Do pollster-specific matrices forecast better? Leave-one-election-out backtest

Model	Level	Mean seat error per
Raw average (no correction)	–	
Industry family bias, EB-shrunk	industry	
Pollster × family bias matrix (house effects, half carry-over)	pollster-specific	
Pollster bias + slope matrix, inverted line	pollster-specific	
Pollster calibration matrix (truth on poll: bias + slope)	pollster-specific	
Industry + composition + pollster × segment deviations	pollster-specific	
Industry + composition, NMF ensemble (selected)	**industry**	

Choosing the model: leave-one-election-out backtest

Each method is fitted on seven elections and scored on the eighth, using the competition metric (sum of absolute seat errors). This is repeated for all eight elections.

Mean score per election (lower is better)



Bars: main model classes. The highlighted bar (lowest score) is the model used for 2026. Paired tests against the raw average are in the table below.

The raw firm average scores **20.00** seats of absolute error per election. The shrunk industry family correction gives **18.75**; the segment-composition model averaged over all NMF segmentations gives **19.00**; their combination gives **18.75**. The lowest score among the pre-specified candidates is used for 2026; the ensemble ties with the industry correction on the merged history (it won outright, 18.25 vs 18.75, on the English-Wikipedia history alone) and, as the pre-specified primary model, is kept: **Industry + composition (NMF)**, 18.75 (4 wins / 2 losses vs raw, Wilcoxon p = 0.531).

With only eight elections no comparison is significant (Friedman $\chi^2 = 6.32$, $p = 0.61$; Nemenyi critical difference 4.25 ranks). The clearest result is a warning: choosing the

single best of 126 clustering configurations on seven elections and testing on the eighth scores **20.50**, worse than doing nothing. That winner's-curse result is why the final model averages over segmentations instead of picking one.

Held-out election	Raw average, one vote per firm	Industry family bias (EB-shrunk)
2009	16	16
2013	22	20
2015	20	22
2019a	44	38
2019b	12	10
2020	8	6
2021	26	26
2022	12	12
Mean	**20.00**	**18.75**

The 2026 polls: one campaign, two pictures

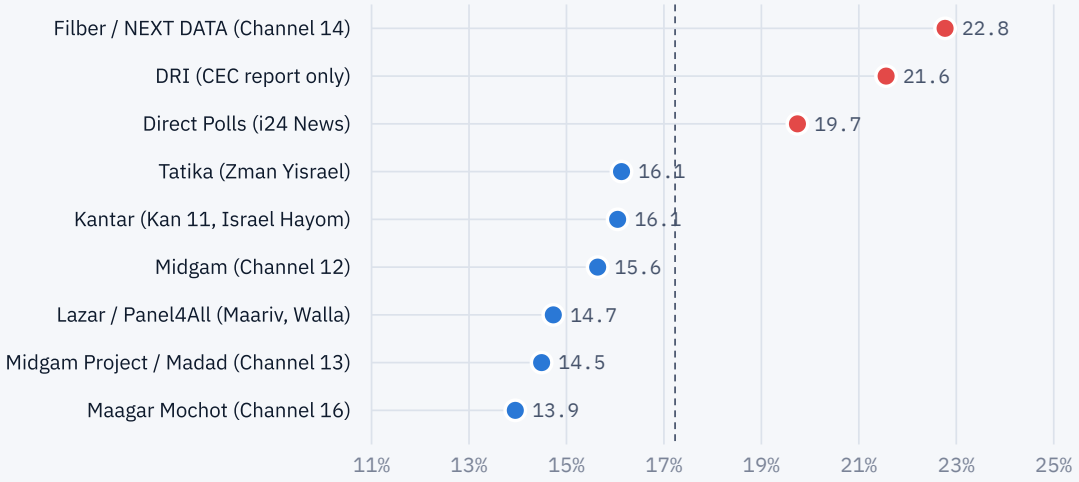
In the final ten days, three firms (Channel 14's Filber/NEXT DATA, i24's Direct Polls and the independent DRI poll) put Likud near its 2022 level. The six mainstream firms show Likud losing about a quarter of its 2022 vote, mostly to Yashar! and Together. The Arab-list total is almost the same at every firm. The gap is about one question: will disaffected 2022 Likud voters come back? Filber's panel says 90% will; a Midgam panel in May said only 58% would "definitely" vote Likud again. The firms also treat undecided voters and 2022-vote weighting differently.

History does not settle it. Direct Polls leaned only 1.5–2.7 bloc seats to the right of the field in 2020–2022, and in 2022 it was the closest firm on the bloc. The 2026 gaps (+13 for Channel 14, +8 for i24) are three to five times its largest past lean. NEXT DATA is a new firm, co-owned by Channel 14's owner, with response rates of 1–6% and a formal petition over its filings. DRI's methodology is undocumented. The backtest found no weighting that beats one vote

per firm, so each firm counts once, and the disagreement becomes an explicit uncertainty term. The call is robust: dropping Channel 14 or DRI, halving their weight, or giving the whole right-leaning camp one shared vote moves Likud by at most one seat (see the sensitivity table).

Likud: vote share by firm

Likud | Yashar! | Together | Shas | Yisrael Beiteinu | Hendel–Zelicha | Amcha Israel



Time-weighted mean of each firm's polls fielded 14–23 Oct; seats converted to votes as in the historical calibration (lists below the threshold at their reported %). Dashed line: equal-weight mean across firms (before corrections). mainstream right-leaning

Firm	Likud	Yashar	Together	Dems	YB	Otzma
Midgam Project / Madad (Channel 13) main	14.5	16.1	10.8	7.7	6.5	6.0
DRI (CEC report only) right	21.6	17.8	7.2	6.4	5.7	6.4
Direct Polls (i24 News) right	19.7	15.9	9.6	6.8	5.1	7.0
Kantar (Kan 11, Israel Hayom) main	16.1	17.6	10.6	6.6	6.2	6.5
Lazar / Panel4All (Maariv, Walla) main	14.7	16.9	11.3	7.6	6.5	6.1
Maagar Mochot (Channel 16) main	13.9	16.3	11.6	7.4	5.8	7.4
Midgam (Channel 12) main	15.6	17.8	11.5	7.5	6.4	6.1
Filber / NEXT DATA (Channel 14) right	22.8	15.5	8.0	6.9	4.5	6.2
Tatika (Zman Yisrael) main	16.1	18.3	8.7	6.5	7.2	6.3
Equal-weight mean (raw)	**17.2**	**16.9**	**9.9**	**7.0**	**6.0**	**6.4**

Firm	Likud	Yashar	Together	Dems	YB	Otzma
Average disagreement	17.9	17.2	10.1	6.7	5.9	5.7

Is the disagreement real? Heterogeneity test across firms

List	Firm range (% of vote)	Q (df 8)	p-value	I^2
Likud	**13.9–22.8**	**250.6**	**< 0.0001**	**0.97**
Together (Bennett-Lapid)	**7.2–11.6**	**72.1**	**< 0.0001**	**0.89**
Amcha Israel (Winter)	**1.8–3.5**	**47.5**	**< 0.0001**	**0.83**
Yisrael Beiteinu	**4.5–7.2**	**36.9**	**< 0.0001**	**0.78**
Hendel & Zelicha (Reservists)	**1.8–3.5**	**29.7**	**0.0002**	**0.73**
Shas	**5.5–7.6**	**27.9**	**0.0005**	**0.71**
Yashar! (Eisenkot)	15.5–18.3	12.4	0.1323	0.36
Otzma Yehudit	6.0–7.4	10.7	0.2223	0.25
The Democrats	6.4–7.7	6.0	0.6508	0.00
United Torah Judaism	5.6–6.4	1.8	0.9857	0.00
Religious Zionism & Zehut	4.9–7.2	7.6	0.4761	0.00
Joint List (Hadash-Ta'al-Balad)	6.3–7.4	7.1	0.5312	0.00
Ra'am	4.1–5.2	6.1	0.6402	0.00

Cochran's Q across the nine firms' means (binomial standard errors, effective sample size = total n / 1.5). I^2 is the share of between-firm variation that sampling error cannot explain. The disagreement is concentrated in Likud, Together, Yisrael Beiteinu, Shas and the two threshold lists, which is the axis the simulation's "which firms are right" shock follows.

From corrected polls to seats

Each simulated election perturbs the corrected log vote shares with three things. First, a shock shared by lists of the same family. Second, a list-level shock sized by the out-of-sample error of lists of similar size (log sd 0–4%: 0.36; 4–8%: 0.18; 8–15%: 0.18; 15–100%: 0.11). Third, a "which firms are right" shock along the leading principal axis of 2026 firm disagreement (Likud and Shas against Together, Yashar and the threshold lists). Unpolled

small lists get about 1.2% of the vote. Each draw then goes through the exact allocation law with the 2026 surplus agreements.
The uncertainty model was itself back-tested. Each past election was re-simulated from its leave-one-out corrected average, using error sizes estimated only from the other elections.

89%

of actual seat counts fell inside the 80% intervals (target 80%)

0.115

Brier score for passing the threshold, 48 lists polled at 1.5–6% (always guessing the base rate: 0.177)

19.7 / 18.0

expected vs realised seat error per election in the backtest

73% / 77%

predicted vs observed share of near-threshold lists passing (Platt recalibration intercept 0.39, p = 0.38)

Sensitivity: forecast seats under alternative choices

Variant	Likud	Yashar	Together	Dems	YB	Otzma	S
Main forecast	**23**	**22**	**13**	**8**	**8**	**7**	
Industry correction only	23	23	13	8	8	7	
No correction	22	22	13	9	8	8	
Without DRI	23	22	14	8	8	7	
Without Channel 14	22	23	14	8	8	7	
Mainstream firms only	20	22	14	8	8	7	
Right-leaning firms only	29	21	11	8	6	7	
6-day window	24	22	13	8	8	7	
14-day window	24	22	13	8	8	7	
No disagreement shock	23	22	13	8	8	7	
Double disagreement shock	24	22	13	8	8	7	
Family shock sd 0.15	24	22	13	8	8	7	
With pollster house effects	24	22	13	8	8	7	

Variant	Likud	Yashar	Together	Dems	YB	Otzma	S
NEXT DATA & DRI at half weight	23	22	14	8	8	7	
Right-leaning camp shares one vote	22	22	14	9	8	7	
Composition model only (E5)	24	22	13	8	7	7	
Raw CEC-report % instead of seat conversion	24	22	13	9	7	7	

Turnout

Official turnout divides voters by every registered voter, including Israelis living abroad, who cannot vote by mail. CBS puts them at about 810,000 in 2026 (11.0% of the register), up from about 600,000 (8.8%) in 2022. That alone lowers official turnout by about 1.7 points at unchanged behaviour. The model therefore works with the electorate living in Israel and one consistent sector definition (Arab and Druze localities, the standard Rudnitzky series):

- **2022 calibration:** turnout among voters living in Israel was 77.5%; in Arab and Druze localities 53.2%; among everyone else 81.7%.
- **Arab-sector turnout 2026:** 62% ± 4.5. Kantar's final poll and Afkar expect about 60%. Stat-Net's late estimate of 68–69% is about 65% after correcting for its own 2022 overestimate. The Konrad Adenauer survey brackets 53–67% depending on list structure. The seat forecast's 16 Arab-list seats imply about 64–69%, so the centre sits above the 60% consensus.
- **Everyone else:** +1 ± 2 points vs 2022. Signals: 80–82% "certain to vote" in Kantar's final poll, and diplomatic-mission turnout of 86.7% vs 69.6% in 2022 (CEC). Offsets: new immigrants and a possible Gur Hasidim abstention. Up to 50,000 expats flying in add a little.

Median of 200,000 draws: **71.2%** (80% range 69.0–73.3%), about 5.22 million voters. Turnout only breaks ties in the competition, so the median is reported (it minimises expected absolute error).

Limitations and independent review

Before this version, the full pipeline went through an adversarial code review: four independent reviewers, each finding checked by a skeptical verifier who tried to refute it by re-running the code. Every issue that could move numbers was fixed and the whole chain re-run. The main ones:

- lists that polls showed at 0 seats entered the bias estimates at placeholder shares; family errors are now size-weighted over measured lists only;
- seats were converted to votes as seats/120, which put 4-seat lists below the threshold they had passed; the D'Hondt-midpoint conversion fixed a measurable under-confidence in threshold probabilities and improved the raw baseline from 22.5 to 20.0 seats per election;
- NMF hard labels ignored archetype scale;
- a 2014 poll was dated inside the 2015 final fortnight;
- 58 duplicated 2015 ballot ids were double-counted at settlement level;
- an undefined composition multiplier occurred when a party family was absent from the base election;
- the segment model's baseline left out double-envelope votes (soldiers, diplomats and others, about 10% of votes). A perfect poll would still have been "corrected". An explicit double-envelope segment now makes an unbiased poll reproduce the official result exactly.

Known limitations that remain:

- Only eight elections are available, so most method comparisons are not significant at 5%. That is why the final model averages over segmentations instead of choosing one.
- Segmentations are fitted on all ten elections, including each held-out one. They use vote composition only, never poll errors. A verification re-fitted the NMF segmentations inside every backtest fold and got identical backtest scores.
- The out-of-sample calibration covers the historical error terms. The 2026 firm-disagreement term is added deliberately on top, because the heterogeneity test shows it is real.

Reproducibility

Everything runs from the `forecast_k26/code` folder, in order: `01_download_data.py` → `02_parse_results.py` → `03_parse_wiki_polls.py` → `04_build_poll_datasets.py` → `04b_merge_hewiki_polls.py` → `05_clustering.py` → `06_poll_error_analysis.py` →

`06b_model_selection.py` → `06c_final_factors.py` → `06d_calibration.py` → `06e_pollster_profiles.py` → `07_forecast_2026.py` → `07b_firm_heterogeneity.py` → `08_turnout.py` → `09_build_report.py`. Shared mappings and the seat-allocation law live in `config.py`. Every intermediate table is in `outputs/tables`, and `docs/DECISION_LOG.md` logs each decision in order. `README.md` is the entry point.

Verified reproducible. `reproduce_from_raw.sh` rebuilds everything from the raw downloads in an isolated copy (steps 02–09). It reproduced the submitted seat vector exactly (zero difference for every list) and the same turnout, 71.2%. The full run takes about 17 minutes on a laptop CPU.